Northwind Marketplace
Listing Policy & Brand Content Guide

Version 2.0 | Effective 1 October 2026
Applies to all product and service listings

Purpose. This document defines the rules every listing must meet before it can be approved, and the writing standards that make listings clear, honest, and consistent. It is written for sellers, human reviewers, and automated review tools.

How to cite. Every rule has a stable identifier such as **POL-4.2** (Policy) or **BRD-3.1** (Brand guide). Reviewers and tools must cite the identifier whenever they report a finding. Identifiers never change between small revisions.

Note. Northwind Marketplace is a fictional marketplace created as a reference policy for the Marketplace Listing Quality Reviewer project. Rules are modelled on common industry practice but are not the policy of any real company.

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Part A. Policy

1. Scope and definitions

POL-1.1 This policy applies to every listing submitted to Northwind Marketplace, whether it offers a physical product, a digital product, or a service.

POL-1.2 **Listing**: a single offer made up of the fields in Section 2. **Seller**: the person or business making the offer. **Claim**: any statement about performance, origin, quality, safety, results, or comparison that a buyer could rely on.

POL-1.3 **Unverifiable claim**: a claim that cannot be confirmed from the listing itself or from a document, certification, or measurement the seller supplies. Unverifiable claims are not automatically prohibited, but must be flagged and handled under Section 6.

POL-1.4 **Assumption**: information a reviewer or tool would have to guess in order to judge a listing, such as an unstated condition, size, compatibility, or service area. Reviewers must name assumptions explicitly rather than silently relying on them.

2. Required listing fields

POL-2.1 Every listing must include a non-empty **Title**, **Description**, **Category**, **Price**, **Attributes**, and **Seller**.

POL-2.2 **Tags** are optional. If supplied they must meet Section 14.

POL-2.3 A field that contains only whitespace, placeholder text (for example "TBD", "N/A", "test", "lorem ipsum"), or repeated characters is treated as missing.

POL-2.4 **Attributes** must contain at least the attributes required for the chosen category in Section 4. A listing missing one or more required attributes is incomplete.

POL-2.5 **Seller** must be a display name of 2 to 60 characters. It must not contain a phone number, email address, or web address (see POL-9.2).

3. Field format and length rules

POL-3.1 The title must be 15 to 80 characters long.

POL-3.2 The description must be 80 to 2,000 characters long.

POL-3.3 The price must be a positive number with at most two decimal places. Do not use a currency symbol or a thousands comma. Use a period for decimals. Example: 49.99. All prices are in USD.

POL-3.4 The price must be between 0.01 and 100,000.00. A price of 0 is not allowed.

POL-3.5 The category must match one of the supported categories in Section 4. Capital letters do not matter.

POL-3.6 Tags: no more than 10, each 2 to 30 characters long.

POL-3.7 The seller name must be 2 to 60 characters long.

POL-3.8 Length is measured in characters after trimming leading and trailing whitespace and collapsing runs of whitespace into a single space.

POL-3.9 Text must be plain text. HTML tags, markdown formatting, and control characters are not permitted in any field.

4. Supported categories and required attributes

POL-4.1 Only the categories below are supported. Listings in any other category are rejected as out of scope. Each category lists the attributes that must appear in the Attributes field.

- **Electronics** - brand, model, condition, warranty
- **Home & Kitchen** - brand, material, dimensions, condition
- **Fashion & Apparel** - brand, size, material, condition
- **Beauty & Personal Care** - brand, volume or weight, ingredients, expiry or batch date
- **Sports & Outdoors** - brand, condition, size or dimensions
- **Books & Media** - title or author, format, condition, language
- **Toys & Games** - brand, recommended age range, condition, safety standard
- **Home Services** - service type, service area, availability, pricing basis (hourly, fixed, per visit)
- **Professional Services** - service type, delivery method, turnaround time, pricing basis
- **Digital Products** - format, platform or compatibility, licence type, delivery method

POL-4.2 **Condition** must be one of: New, Open box, Refurbished, Used - like new, Used - good, Used - acceptable. A condition not in this list must be flagged.

POL-4.3 The title, description, and attributes must be consistent with the chosen category. A kitchen blender listed under Electronics, or a legal consultation listed under Home Services, is a miscategorisation.

POL-4.4 Where an attribute value contradicts the title or description (for example the title says "Brand new" and condition says Used - good), the listing is internally inconsistent and must be corrected.

5. Prohibited and restricted content

5.1 Prohibited items and services

The following may never be listed. A listing containing any of them must be rejected.

POL-5.1 Weapons, firearms, ammunition, explosives, and parts or instructions to make them.

POL-5.2 Illegal drugs, drug paraphernalia, and prescription medication offered without a valid pharmacy licence.

POL-5.3 Counterfeit, replica, or "inspired by" goods that use another brand's name, logo, or trade dress to suggest they are genuine.

POL-5.4 Stolen goods, and goods whose sale infringes copyright, trademark, or licensing terms.

POL-5.5 Personal data, hacked accounts, credentials, or services to bypass security, forge documents, or fake reviews.

POL-5.6 Adult sexual content and services.

POL-5.7 Live animals, human organs, and human remains.

POL-5.8 Tobacco, vaping products, and alcohol.

5.2 Restricted content

Restricted content may be listed only if the stated conditions are met. Otherwise the listing must be revised or rejected.

POL-5.9 Supplements and wellness products may be listed under Beauty & Personal Care only. Listings must not state or imply that the product diagnoses, treats, cures, or prevents any disease or medical condition.

POL-5.10 Children's products must state a recommended age range and the safety standard they meet (for example EN 71 or ASTM F963). Toys with small parts must carry a choking-hazard notice if intended for children under 3.

POL-5.11 Electrical products must state voltage and plug type, or state that they are battery-powered.

POL-5.12 Used electronics must state battery health, or state that battery condition is unknown.

POL-5.13 Cosmetics must list ingredients and must not be sold past their expiry date.

POL-5.14 Regulated services (legal, medical, financial, tax advice) must state the seller's licence or registration number, or must be described as general information only and not advice.

6. Claims, accuracy, and substantiation

POL-6.1 Every listing must be accurate and must not mislead a reasonable buyer. Omitting a material fact (such as a defect or a limit on compatibility) is treated the same as stating something false.

POL-6.2 Superlatives and absolute claims ("best", "#1", "perfect", "guaranteed", "100%", "never fails", "the only") require substantiation. Without a stated source, test, award, or certification, they must be removed or softened.

POL-6.3 Health, safety, and performance claims that can be measured (battery life, speed, coverage, SPF, waterproof rating, weight capacity) must state the measurement conditions or the standard used.

POL-6.4 Comparative claims ("better than", "faster than", "cheaper than") must name the comparison target and basis, or be removed.

POL-6.5 Certification and endorsement claims ("FDA approved", "doctor recommended", "eco-certified", "award-winning") must name the certifying body, certificate number, or award, or be removed. Medical endorsements without a named practitioner are not permitted.

POL-6.6 Origin claims ("handmade", "made in", "organic", "vegan", "genuine leather") must be supported by an attribute or a specific statement. Otherwise they are unverifiable.

POL-6.7 Urgency and scarcity claims ("only 2 left", "limited time", "act now", "sale ends today") are not allowed unless the listing states a real, specific end date or quantity.

POL-6.8 Time-based or result-based claims ("lose 5 kg in a week", "doubles your income", "results in 24 hours") are not allowed for any product or service.

POL-6.9 Unverifiable claims: when a claim cannot be checked from the listing, a reviewer must (a) quote the claim, (b) state that it is unverifiable, (c) cite POL-1.3 and the relevant claim rule, and (d) suggest either substantiation the seller can add or neutral replacement wording. A reviewer must never invent evidence to support a claim.

POL-6.10 **Assumptions**: when a judgement depends on information not in the listing, a reviewer must list the assumption separately from findings, and must not treat an assumption as confirmed fact.

POL-6.11 Statements about the seller's own track record ("trusted by thousands", "5-star seller", "top-rated") are unverifiable claims unless supported by marketplace-generated data shown elsewhere on the platform.

7. Pricing and fee transparency

POL-7.1 The Price field is the total price the buyer pays for the item or for the stated unit of service, excluding shipping and taxes handled at checkout.

POL-7.2 Description text must not name a price that differs from the Price field. Extra charges (setup fees, call-out fees, minimum order) must be disclosed in the description.

POL-7.3 "Was" and "now" prices, discount percentages, and "save X" claims are allowed only if the listing states the original price and that it was genuinely charged by this seller within the previous 30 days.

POL-7.4 Prices that appear implausibly low for the category (for example a new flagship phone below 10 USD) or implausibly high must be flagged for review as a possible error or scam, and the reviewer must not state the true market price as fact.

POL-7.5 For services, the pricing basis (hourly, fixed, per visit, per project) must be stated in Attributes. A bare price for a service with no basis is incomplete.

POL-7.6 Requests for payment outside the marketplace, including bank transfer, gift cards, or cryptocurrency, are prohibited.

8. Duplicate and spam listings

POL-8.1 A seller may not publish more than one active listing for the same item or service.

POL-8.2 Two listings are **exact duplicates** when the same seller uses the same normalised title. Normalisation lowercases text, removes punctuation, and collapses whitespace.

POL-8.3 Two listings are **near duplicates** when the same seller uses titles or descriptions that are at least 90 percent similar after normalisation, and Category is the same.

POL-8.4 Different sellers may list the same product. Cross-seller similarity alone is not a violation, but a near-identical description copied from another seller must be flagged for originality.

POL-8.5 Listing variants (different size or colour) should be combined into one listing using Attributes rather than posted as separate listings.

POL-8.6 **Keyword stuffing**: repeating the same word or phrase three or more times in a title, or listing unrelated brand names or search terms, is spam.

POL-8.7 Tags must not repeat the title word for word and must not contain brand names the listing does not actually sell.

9. Seller conduct and contact information

POL-9.1 Sellers are responsible for the accuracy of every field, including content a reviewer or tool suggested and the seller approved.

POL-9.2 Phone numbers, email addresses, social media handles, and web addresses are not allowed in the title, description, attributes, tags, or seller name. Buyers and sellers must communicate through the marketplace.

POL-9.3 Listings must not contain abusive, discriminatory, or threatening language, or content that targets a person or protected group.

POL-9.4 Listings must not ask buyers to leave reviews in exchange for rewards, or to remove negative reviews.

POL-9.5 Listings must be written in English for this marketplace version. Mixed-language text is allowed only for proper nouns and product names.

10. Review outcomes and records

POL-10.1 Every finding must say which field it is about, quote the problem text, explain the issue in simple words, and cite at least one rule ID from this document.

POL-10.2 Every finding must also give a suggested fix or action for the seller.

POL-10.3 A finding that cites no rule from this document is not a valid policy finding. It may only be shown as an optional style suggestion marked "uncited".

POL-10.4 **Listing outcome.** Approved: no blocking problems are left. Needs changes: some problems are still open, or the seller rejected a required fix. Rejected: the listing breaks a prohibited-content rule (Section 5.1) and is not fixed.

POL-10.5 **Audit trail.** Every suggestion, approval, edit, and rejection must be recorded with the field, the original text, the revised text, the person who acted, the action taken, and a timestamp. Records must not be deleted or overwritten.

POL-10.6 Reviewers must not approve their own listings.

Part B. Brand Content Guide

The Brand Content Guide describes how Northwind listings should read. Rules in Part A are mandatory. Rules in Part B are quality standards.

11. Voice and tone

BRD-1.1 **Be clear.** Say what the item or service is, who it is for, and what the buyer gets. Prefer short sentences and common words.

BRD-1.2 **Be honest.** Describe defects, limits, and conditions plainly. Honest detail builds buyer trust and reduces returns.

BRD-1.3 **Be specific.** Replace vague adjectives ("high quality", "amazing", "great value") with measurable facts such as size, material, capacity, or duration.

BRD-1.4 **Be calm.** Avoid hype, pressure, and emotional manipulation.

BRD-1.5 Write in the third person or neutral voice for products. For services, "we" or "I" is allowed when the seller is describing what they will do.

12. Titles

BRD-2.1 Use the pattern **Brand + Product type + Key feature + Size or model** where applicable. Example: "Aurora 20000mAh Power Bank, 22.5W Fast Charging, Black".

BRD-2.2 Use Title Case or sentence case. Do not write the whole title in capital letters. Capitalised acronyms and brand styling are allowed.

BRD-2.3 Do not use emojis, decorative symbols, repeated punctuation (!!!, ???), or promotional phrases such as "SALE", "HOT", "FREE SHIPPING", "BEST PRICE".

BRD-2.4 Put the most important words first. Buyers often see only the first 50 characters.

BRD-2.5 A title must describe one item or one service. Do not combine unrelated offers.

BRD-2.6 For services, start with the service and place: "Residential Deep Cleaning, 2-Bedroom Apartment, Ahmedabad".

13. Descriptions

BRD-3.1 Open with a one-sentence summary of what is offered.

BRD-3.2 Organise the body as: what it is, key features, specifications, what is included, condition or limits, and how delivery or service works.

BRD-3.3 State what is **not** included, or what the item does not work with, whenever a buyer might reasonably assume otherwise.

BRD-3.4 Use plain sentences or simple line breaks. Do not use all-caps passages, decorative lines, or emoji.

BRD-3.5 Do not repeat the title as the entire description. The description must add information not already in the title.

BRD-3.6 Keep each paragraph under about 80 words. Avoid filler openings such as "Welcome to my shop".

BRD-3.7 Express measurements with units and, for services, durations with units (for example 90 minutes). Do not leave units implied.

BRD-3.8 State the item condition and any wear, damage, or missing parts in the first half of the description for used or refurbished goods.

14. Attributes and tags

BRD-4.1 Write attributes as consistent key-value pairs, for example "brand: Aurora", "condition: New", "warranty: 12 months".

BRD-4.2 Use standard units and spellings. Use "cm", "kg", "ml" rather than free text such as "big" or "heavy".

BRD-4.3 Attribute values must be specific. "warranty: yes" is incomplete; "warranty: 12 months, seller-provided" is acceptable.

BRD-4.4 Tags are short search terms (1 to 3 words) in lowercase. They must be relevant to the listing and must not repeat the title.

BRD-4.5 Do not use tags to add claims the description does not support.

15. Rewrite examples

These examples show how a reviewer should rewrite problem wording. Each example cites the rules involved.

• **BEST EVER Headphones!!! LIMITED TIME SALE**
Problem: All caps, hype, urgency, unverifiable superlative, no product detail.
Suggested rewrite: Aurora Wireless Over-Ear Headphones, Bluetooth 5.3, Black
Rules: BRD-2.2, BRD-2.3, POL-6.2, POL-6.7

• **This supplement cures anxiety and guarantees results in 7 days.**
Problem: Disease-treatment claim and result guarantee.
Suggested rewrite: Daily magnesium supplement, 60 capsules. Check ingredients and consult a health professional before use.
Rules: POL-5.9, POL-6.8, POL-6.2

• **Genuine leather bag, handmade, trusted by thousands.**
Problem: Unsupported origin and seller-track-record claims.
Suggested rewrite: Leather shoulder bag, 32 x 24 x 10 cm. Material: cowhide leather. Handmade by the seller (supply a photo of the label or maker note to confirm).
Rules: POL-6.6, POL-6.11, BRD-1.3

• **Phone like new, call me 98XXXXXXXX for lowest price.**
Problem: Contact details, vague condition, comparative claim.
Suggested rewrite: Used smartphone, 128 GB, condition: Used - like new. Light scratches on the back. Battery health: 91%.
Rules: POL-9.2, POL-6.4, POL-5.12, BRD-3.8

• **Cleaning service. Cheap.**
Problem: No scope, no area, no pricing basis.
Suggested rewrite: Residential deep cleaning for apartments up to 2 bedrooms. Includes kitchen, bathrooms, and floors. Service area: Ahmedabad. Duration: about 4 hours.

Rules: POL-7.5, POL-4.1, BRD-3.2, BRD-3.7

• **Waterproof speaker, battery lasts forever**
Problem: Unmeasured performance claim.
Suggested rewrite: Portable Bluetooth speaker, IPX7 water resistance (tested in 1 m of water for 30 minutes), up to 12 hours playback at 50% volume.
Rules: POL-6.3, POL-6.2